STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



KPIS

NPS, CSAT, CES: WHAT THEY REALLY MEASURE

Why a 6 counts as a detractor, what customer effort does to loyalty, three metrics and three questions, whether NPS predicts growth, one set of answers with three scores, and a card.

6 out of 10 counts as a detractor in the Net Promoter Score, just like a 0.

REICHHELD, 2003

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NO. 32 · KPIS

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Most companies ask their customers for a number. What do NPS, CSAT and CES each measure, how well do they predict what matters, and how do you read a score without fooling yourself?

Fred Reichheld's Net Promoter Score counts a 6 out of 10 as a detractor, just like a 0, and very different teams can end up with the same score. Studies from Norway and the US could not confirm that NPS predicts growth better than satisfaction measures, and across 93 firms satisfaction measured as top-2-box predicted retention best. In CEB's research, 96% of customers who had to work hard to get help became more disloyal, against 9% when it was easy.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

A 6 is a detractor

In December 2003 Fred Reichheld proposed in Harvard Business Review that one question could replace long satisfaction surveys: how likely is it that you would recommend the company to a friend or colleague, from 0 to 10?

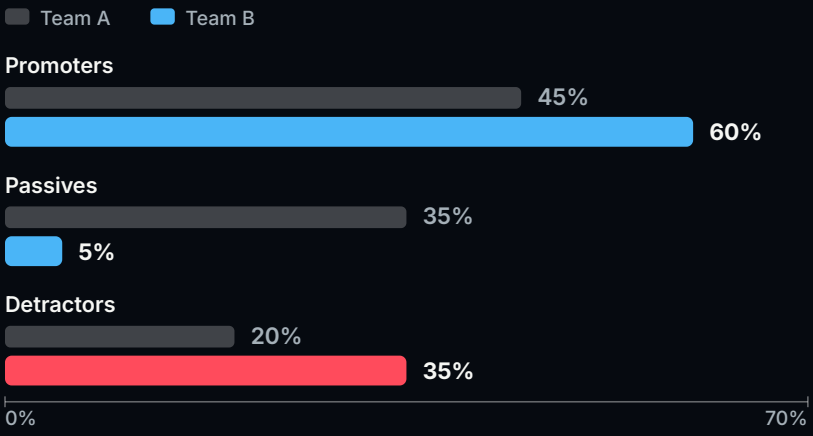
0–6
Detractors
count against the score

7–8
Passives
count in the total, not in the score

9–10
Promoters
count for the score

NPS is the share of promoters minus the share of detractors, from −100 to +100. Two teams can reach the same score in very different ways:

TWO HYPOTHETICAL TEAMS, BOTH WITH AN NPS OF +25 (% OF ANSWERS)



Source: Frederick F. Reichheld, Harvard Business Review, 2003

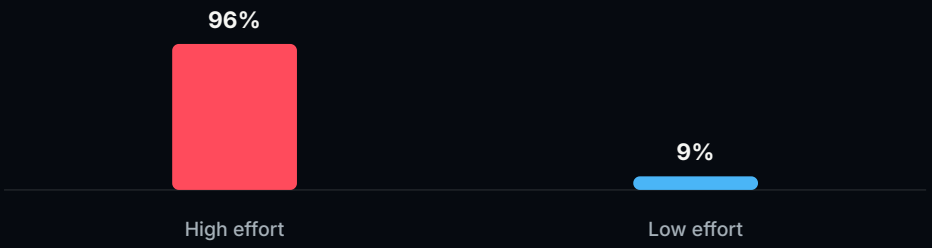
The teams and numbers are invented; the method follows Reichheld (2003). Net Promoter and NPS are registered trademarks of Bain & Company, NICE Systems and Fred Reichheld.

THE NUMBERS

Effort costs loyalty

In 2010 Matthew Dixon, Karen Freeman and Nicholas Toman reported a study of more than 75,000 customers who had contacted service by phone, web, chat or email. Delighting customers, they concluded, does not build loyalty; reducing their effort does.

CUSTOMERS WHO BECAME MORE DISLOYAL AFTER A SERVICE INTERACTION (CEB RESEARCH, SELF-REPORTED)



In CEB's research, service interactions were about four times more likely to drive disloyalty than loyalty. The 2010 article introduced the Customer Effort Score; in 2013 CEB replaced the first question with a statement rated from 1 to 7: the company made it easy for me to handle my issue.

OUR READING

Customers rarely walk away from service that failed to dazzle. They walk away from service that made them work.

Sources: Matthew Dixon, Karen Freeman & Nicholas Toman, Harvard Business Review, 2010; Matthew Dixon, Nick Toman & Rick DeLisi, Portfolio/Penguin, 2013 (via Summaries of the book, through web search)

The research comes from CEB, a firm that sold the method, and rests on intentions customers reported; their behaviour was not measured.

THE MODEL

Three metrics, three questions

The three best-known customer metrics ask different questions, so they measure different things. None of them is a standard, and CSAT has no owner at all.

NPS

Would you recommend us?

0 to 10; share of 9–10 minus share of 0–6

CSAT

How satisfied were you?

often 1 to 5; often the share of the two highest answers

CES

Was it easy?

since 2013, agreement from 1 to 7 with a statement

THE MODEL BEHIND THE AMERICAN CUSTOMER SATISFACTION INDEX (ACSI), 1994

01	02	03	04
Expectations	**Quality and value**	**Satisfaction**	**Complaints, loyalty**
what customers expect	as customers perceive them	scored from 0 to 100	the consequences

OUR READING

Recommendation, satisfaction and effort are different things. Pick the question that fits the decision you have to make.

Sources: Frederick F. Reichheld, Harvard Business Review, 2003; Neil A. Morgan & Lopo Leotte Rego, Marketing Science, 2006 (via Abstract); Matthew Dixon, Nick Toman & Rick DeLisi, Portfolio/Penguin, 2013 (via Summaries of the book, through web search); Claes Fornell et al., Journal of Marketing, 1996 (via Abstract)

The CSAT practice is common usage, with no formal standard. The ACSI has been published since October 1994; its satisfaction score is a weighted average of three questions.

More in the essay 61 resellers: what wholesale taught me about trust

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Does it predict growth?

Reichheld wrote that the recommend question predicts loyalty and growth better than satisfaction surveys. Independent studies tested the claim.

01	**Keiningham et al., 2007**	21 firms and over 15,500 interviews in Norway, compared with the ACSI: no clear superiority of Net Promoter over other measures.
02	**Morgan & Rego, 2006**	ACSI data for 1994–2000: average satisfaction predicted business performance best; recommendation measures had little or no value.
03	**de Haan et al., 2015**	Customers of 93 firms in 18 industries: top-2-box satisfaction predicted retention best; the best metric varied by industry, and combining helped.

OUR READING

No single number wins everywhere. Which one predicts best depends on the business, so test it on your own customers.

Sources: Timothy L. Keiningham et al., Journal of Marketing, 2007; Neil A. Morgan & Lopo Leotte Rego, Marketing Science, 2006 (via Abstract); Evert de Haan, Peter C. Verhoef & Thorsten Wiesel, International Journal of Research in Marketing, 2015

The studies show associations and do not prove cause. Morgan and Rego did not use the 0–10 question. Each camp has an interest: Bain advises on NPS, CEB sold CES research, and Ipsos announced the 2007 critique.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

One set of answers, three scores

CSAT is often reported as top-2-box: the share of answers in the two highest points of the scale. Change the rule and the same answers give a different number.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, 100 ANSWERS ON A 1–5 SCALE

Answers	5: 30 · 4: 40 · 3: 15 · 2: 10 · 1: 5
Top-2-box	4s and 5s of all answers: 70%
No neutrals	the 3s left out of the count: 70 of 85 = 82%
Top box	only the 5s: 30%

Say which rule you use, and stick to it. All answers here are made up.

1. **Fix the question, the scale and the rule**
   Otherwise a change in the score may only be a change in the method.
2. **Report the spread alongside the score**
   The same score can hide very different customers.
3. **Keep the score out of bonuses**
   NPS's own authors say tying it to frontline bonuses made people chase the score.

Sources: Evert de Haan, Peter C. Verhoef & Thorsten Wiesel, International Journal of Research in Marketing, 2015; Fred Reichheld, Darci Darnell & Maureen Burns, Harvard Business Review, 2021

The steps and the example are the editors'. Top-2-box follows the studies of Morgan & Rego and de Haan et al.; on bonuses, Reichheld, Darnell & Burns (2021).

Open the tool: Last-Mile CX Control Tower stivencatalyst.com/tools/cx-control-tower/

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The voice-of-the-customer card

One card per month. The score is the start of the conversation: the spread, the reasons and the effort tell you what to fix.

01 Question and scale word for word, and the rule for the score

02 Answers how many, and how many customers did not answer

03 Score and spread the score, and the share in each group

04 Top three reasons from the comments of the lowest scores

05 Where customers worked hard repeat contacts, switching channels, waiting

06 One fix what, who, by when; check it next month

Sources: Frederick F. Reichheld, Harvard Business Review, 2003; Matthew Dixon, Karen Freeman & Nicholas Toman, Harvard Business Review, 2010

Our card, after Reichheld (2003) and Dixon, Freeman & Toman (2010).

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The One Number You Need to Grow
Frederick F. Reichheld, Harvard Business Review, 2003
https://hbr.org/2003/12/the-one-number-you-need-to-grow

Stop Trying to Delight Your Customers
Matthew Dixon, Karen Freeman & Nicholas Toman, Harvard Business Review, 2010
https://hbr.org/2010/07/stop-trying-to-delight-your-customers

The Effortless Experience: Conquering the New Battleground for Customer Loyalty
Matthew Dixon, Nick Toman & Rick DeLisi, Portfolio/Penguin, 2013 · via Summaries of the book, through web search

The American Customer Satisfaction Index: Nature, Purpose, and Findings
Claes Fornell et al., Journal of Marketing, 1996 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.2307/1251898

The Value of Different Customer Satisfaction and Loyalty Metrics in Predicting Business Performance
Neil A. Morgan & Lopo Leotte Rego, Marketing Science, 2006 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1287/mksc.1050.0180

A Longitudinal Examination of Net Promoter and Firm Revenue Growth
Timothy L. Keiningham et al., Journal of Marketing, 2007
https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkg.71.3.39

The predictive ability of different customer feedback metrics for retention
Evert de Haan, Peter C. Verhoef & Thorsten Wiesel, International Journal of Research in Marketing, 2015
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijresmar.2015.02.004

Net Promoter 3.0
Fred Reichheld, Darci Darnell & Maureen Burns, Harvard Business Review, 2021
https://www.bain.com/insights/net-promoter-3-0/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html